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Calif. Dems: Won't Tie Fire Aid to Trump Resistance

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The California Legislature's top two Democrats agreed not to link aid for the fires in Los Angeles to funding to resist the second Trump administration, according to a report from Politico.

Assembly Speaker Robert Rivas and Senate pro Tem Mike McGuire told the outlet's California Playbook that they won't tie the $2.5 billion in fire response and mitigation to the $50 million earmarked for lawsuits against the incoming Trump White House.

The commitment from the two Golden State Democrats echoes a similar pledge made by the state's Democrat governor, Gavin Newsom, who announced the fire aid earlier this week and called a special Trump-proofing session of the legislature.

The move spares Republicans, who had protested the possibility of being forced to choose between helping Southern California and rejecting the funding to target Trump, from having to make a difficult decision.

According to Politico, the agreement was reached during a meeting of legislative leaders in Sacramento and ended the speculation about how state lawmakers would handle the special legislative session after Newsom included the fire aid.

Neither Rivas nor McGuire had previously said if they wanted to combine or separate the funding streams and Newsom reportedly did not indicate a preference until Tuesday.

In a statement, Newsom administration spokesperson Tara Gallegos said that the governor "wants the disaster aid passed on its own and approved swiftly without any unnecessary delays."

On Monday, state Senate Budget Committee Chair Scott Wiener said he planned to combine the funding into one package, which caused Republicans to accuse Democrats of playing politics in the middle of an emergency.

State Senate Republican leader Brian Jones told Playbook on Tuesday that he wished Democrat lawmakers "would stand their ground a little bit and push back on this very bad idea."

The Sacramento agreement between Democrats is not indicative of a deal on the fire aid specifics, but negotiators are reportedly in favor of the Trump-resistance funding.

The state Assembly Democratic Caucus is in the process of reviewing Newsom's proposal to pull $1.5 billion from a recent climate bond and $1 billion from a wildfire emergency fund, Assembly Budget Committee Chair Jesse Gabriel told Playbook in a phone call.

Although he just received the draft language on Monday night, Gabriel said, "We're going to get this done, and we're going to get it done quickly."

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